



Windfall: Cameron Green, formerly with Mumbai Indians and Royal Challengers Bengaluru, learned of his lucrative IPL signing while gearing up for the third Ashes Test against England, a sharp turn of fortune after missing the 2025 season due to back surgery. GETTY IMAGES

the most expensive player of the auction and is now the third-most expensive player in IPL history. The 26-year-old's power-hitting ability, combined with his capacity to deliver disciplined medium pace, sparked a bidding war between KKR and CSK, with the Knight Riders eventually prevailing.

"If we felt it would affect the rest of the auction, we would have let it go. Fortunately, it came within the range we were looking at. He adds a lot to our team, especially with our new power coach Russell," KKR CEO Venky Mysore said.

KKR views Green as a like-for-like

replacement for the now-retired Andre Russell, both in role and impact.

Calculated gamble

While Green's acquisition was largely expected, KKR's move for Pathirana at that price point raised eyebrows. The Sri Lankan slinger endured a difficult IPL 2025, managing just 13 wickets at an economy of 10.14, which led to his release by CSK.

KKR appears to be banking on Pathirana as a long-term death-overs specialist, another role Russell once fulfilled.

Alongside Pathirana and

Mustafizur, the franchise also added Akash Deep and Kartik Tyagi, bolstering an already imposing pace unit that includes Harshit Rana, Vaibhav Arora, and Umran Malik.

Doubling down on youth

CSK's auction strategy reflected a broader shift in philosophy. After a disastrous start to IPL 2025, the franchise introduced young replacements such as Ayush Mhatre, Urvil Patel, and Dewald Brevis, all of whom made an immediate impact.

That youth-first approach carried into the auction. CSK spent the bulk of its purse on uncapped players